PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

Sharecropping & Debt — A House Divided

The Arithmetic of Debt

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about Sharecropping & Debt — A House Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. The injustice is right there in the numbers. Work the ledger and see how the trap closed

THE SOURCES

DATA SET · A SHARECROPPER'S YEAR (TYPICAL FIGURES) — One family's ledger

Item	*Amount*
Value of the family's share of the cotton crop	*$150*
Owed to landowner's store (seed, tools, food) + ~25% interest	*$170*
Carried-over debt from the previous year	*$30.*

Representative figures based on historical accounts. Public domain.

THE IMAGE — The cotton fields



Picking cotton in the South — photograph, early 20th century, public domain (Library of Congress).

YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · RUN THE NUMBERS

Using the ledger: the family's crop share is $150. They owe $170 to the store plus $30 carried over from last year. After the crop is sold, how much does the family end up owing? Show your subtraction.

QUESTION 2 STEP 2 · THE PATTERN

Based on the math, what happens when the next year begins?

- ☐ A. the family owns the land
- ☐ B. the debt disappears
- ☐ C. they start the new year in debt and must borrow again, repeating the cycle
- ☐ D. the landowner pays them extra

QUESTION 3 STEP 3 · WHY THEY COULDN'T LEAVE

A worker in debt usually could not leave to find a better job. Explain how debt — not chains — kept sharecroppers bound to the land. Why is this called “debt peonage”?

QUESTION 4 STEP 4 · SLAVERY'S SHADOW

Sharecropping was not slavery — but historians say it reproduced slavery's core result. Using the numbers you worked out, explain that result in three or four sentences.

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — Sharecropping & Debt — A House Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "$150 – ($170 + $30) = …. The family ends the year owing $___."

QUESTION 2: **Correct — C. they start the new year in debt and must borrow again, repeating the cycle**

Right. The family starts the new year already in debt, has to borrow again, and the cycle repeats — often growing deeper each year. That's the trap.

QUESTION 3: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Debt bound them because…"

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "The numbers show that sharecropping kept Black families…"